One astonishing aspect of SIOP-62 was the intention to attack China, regardless of whether the country was at war with the United States. There was some dissent to this. A meeting of senior officials chaired by Eisenhower's Defense Secretary, Thomas Gates, and including the Joint Chiefs, was told by the Commandant of the Marine Corps, General David Shoup, that 'any plan that murders three hundred million Chinese when it might not even be their war is not a good plan. This is not the American way.'[23] Destruction of 'the Sino-Soviet bloc' nevertheless remained the priority in the US nuclear war plan.

The American way in nuclear war in 1961 was enshrined in the first coordinated war plan, SIOP-62. The joint chiefs explained to the Kennedy administration that in preparing for a crisis over Berlin in 1961 it was necessary to accept the risk of 'general war'.[24] SIOP-62 envisaged both the commitment of the 'full force' and that of alerted forces (i.e., those available after a Soviet attack). Calculating the effectiveness of a retaliatory attack was dependent on readiness states, strategic and tactical warning times, and the scale and nature of Soviet attacks. Assessing the effects of the full force was more straightforward: 295 Soviet cities would be struck with at least one nuclear weapon causing seventy-two per cent casualties in urban areas and fifty-four per cent in the population as a whole.[25] This would entail 108 million dead out of a population of 217 million. The alert force would strike 199 cities. Seventy-eight Chinese cities would be struck by the full force (forty-nine by the alert force), with casualty estimates of fifty-three per cent of the urban population and sixteen per cent of the whole population: 104 million out of a total population of some 650 million.

These estimates only took account of radioactive fallout in the first seventy-two hours. Nor did they consider the effect of fires and firestorms. Curiously, throughout the Cold War, US estimates of casualties in nuclear war involved the effects of blast but did not consider fire damage. Calculating deaths from fires and firestorms was considered too complex. Among the consequences of this, as Lyn Eden has explained, is that because war planning was a basis for procurement, 'the United States has procured